

Module 12: Media, Narratives, and Representation

Signature Learning Experience

Purpose

Students compare how different outlets cover the same migration story and demonstrate, with evidence, how framing works: word choice, sourcing, imagery, and what gets left out. The product is a framing analysis that could teach someone else to read migration news critically.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Identify media bias through systematic comparison, not vibes (UG 1)
- Analyze narratives — the frames outlets construct and repeat (UG 2)
- Explain how coverage shapes public perception (UG 3)
- Compare sources with a documented, repeatable method (UG 4)

Graduate extension

Graduate students scale up to a structured content analysis: a defined sample of 15+ pieces, a written coding scheme, frame frequency counts, and an assessment of how framing tracked a policy moment (Grad 1–2).

Assignment steps

1. Pick one specific migration story or event covered widely within a defined window (e.g., a border policy announcement, a rescue incident, a local resettlement story).
2. Select 4–6 pieces covering it from outlets across the spectrum — include at least one non-US or non-English outlet if possible, and one piece of ethnic/community media.
3. Build a simple comparison instrument: headline language, who is quoted (migrants? officials? advocates?), imagery described or shown, statistics used and their sourcing, what each piece omits.
4. Code each piece with the instrument; put the results in a comparison table.
5. Identify the dominant frame of each piece (threat, victim, contributor, crisis, order/control) and show the textual evidence for your label.
6. Write the analysis: what the comparison reveals, which framings correlate with which sourcing choices, and what a reader of only one outlet would never learn.

Deliverables & format

- Framing analysis, 1,500–1,800 words with the comparison table (graduate: full content analysis with codebook and counts)
- The coded instrument for all pieces (appendix)
- A 'how to read migration news' half-page written for a general reader

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Method: systematic, documented comparison 30%	Method is rigorous and transparent: method: systematic, documented comparison is fully documented, choices are justified, limitations are stated, and another student could replicate the work from what is written.	Method is sound: method: systematic, documented comparison is documented and mostly justified, with limitations acknowledged; small gaps would not change the findings.	Method is partial: method: systematic, documented comparison is described but under-documented or inconsistently applied, leaving findings plausible but not checkable.	Method is absent or unsound: method: systematic, documented comparison is missing, undocumented, or applied so loosely that the findings cannot be trusted.
Evidence for each framing claim — quotes and specifics 30%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: evidence for each framing claim — quotes and specifics is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: evidence for each framing claim — quotes and specifics is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: evidence for each framing claim — quotes and specifics is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: evidence for each framing claim — quotes and specifics is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Insight of the analysis, including omissions 25%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: insight of the analysis, including omissions goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: insight of the analysis, including omissions is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: insight of the analysis, including omissions is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: insight of the analysis, including omissions is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Quality of the general-reader guide 15%	Communication is publication-ready: quality of the general-reader guide is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: quality of the general-reader guide is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: quality of the general-reader guide is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: quality of the general-reader guide is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.